PEER REVIEW HISTORY

BMJ Open publishes all reviews undertaken for accepted manuscripts. Reviewers are asked to complete a checklist review form (**http://bmjopen.bmj.com/site/about/resources/checklist.pdf**) and are provided with free text boxes to elaborate on their assessment. These free text comments are reproduced below.

ARTICLE DETAILS

TITLE (PROVISIONAL)	Interventions to improve infant and young child feeding practices in Ethiopia: a systematic review
AUTHORS	Ahmed, Kedir; Agho, Kingsley; Page, Andrew; Arora, Amit; Ogbo, Felix

VERSION 1 – REVIEW

REVIEWER	Donald Skinner Human Sciences Research Council, Pretoria, Social Aspects of Public Health
REVIEW RETURNED	28-Feb-2021

GENERAL COMMENTS	It is a well written paper that argues the limited evidence well. I liked the effort to incorporate a wide range of studies with different methodologies. This lent it a different feel to the standard systematic review, especially as there was no overall statistical analysis. It also made the paper more readable. The results were less definitive, but gave assured if not unexpected outcomes.

REVIEWER	Helen Morgan Cardiff University, SURE, University Library Service
REVIEW RETURNED	01-Mar-2021

GENERAL COMMENTS	The PRISMA reporting guidelines item 8 state: 'Present full electronic search strategy for at least one database, including any limits used, such that it could be repeated.' The authors have not included a full search strategy for any of the databases that were searched, therefore it is not clear that this systematic review is fully comprehensive and that all relevant literature has ben iidentified. The authors have only provided limited terms in in section 'information sources and serach strategy'. None of the MeSH terms that the authors refer to are listed. If these are the only terms used then they are no comprehensive e.g. set 1: baby, babies missing; plurals and truncation are not considered. I haven't reviewed beyond this point as the review is at serious risk of bias through potentially missing other studies. However some other items to note: Abstract – IYCF in full Line 46-47, rewrite sentence for clarity: all included studies… Results – add information on quality of included studies. Introduction Line 98 and 101: check use of dash as in ‘-1’ and ‘-5’ Materials and methods

	Line 131: should [PRISMA checklist] be here? Table 1: consider additional table grouping studies by outcome PRISMA criteria to be checked and/or amended: 4, 7 and 8

VERSION 1 – AUTHOR RESPONSE

Reviewer #1
Comments to the Author
It is a well written paper that argues the limited evidence well. I liked the effort to incorporate a wide range of studies with different methodologies. This lent it a different feel to the standard systematic review, especially as there was no overall statistical analysis. It also made the paper more readable. The results were less definitive, but gave assured if not unexpected outcomes.
Response:
We thank the reviewer for the comment.

Reviewer #2

The PRISMA reporting guidelines item 8 state: 'Present full electronic search strategy for at least one database, including any limits used, such that it could be repeated.' The authors have not included a full search strategy for any of the databases that were searched, therefore it is not clear that this systematic review is fully comprehensive and that all relevant literature has ben iidentified. The authors have only provided limited terms in in section 'information sources and serach strategy'. None of the MeSH terms that the authors refer to are listed. If these are the only terms used then they are no comprehensive e.g. set 1: baby, babies missing; plurals and truncation are not considered.
Response:
We thank the reviewer for the comment and as noted above, a full electronic search strategy developed for the 'Ovid EMBASE' has been incorporated into the revised manuscript (Supplementary file 2, Page 8 line 195-196).

Abstract
IYCF in full
Response:
Revision done (Page 2 line 33-34)

Line 46-47, rewrite sentence for clarity: all included studies…
Response:
Revision done (Page 2 line 48-50)

Results – add information on quality of included studies.
Response:
Revision done (Page 2 line 54-55)

Introduction
Line 98 and 101: check use of dash as in '-1' and '-5'
Response:
Revision done (Page 4 line 98-101)

Materials and methods
Line 131: should [PRISMA checklist] be here?
Response:

The PRISMA checklist has been incorporated into the revised manuscript as suggested by the Reviewer (Page 5, line 127)

Table 1: consider additional table grouping studies by outcome
Response:
Point appreciated, and Table 2 has been incorporated into the revised manuscript (Page 22).

PRISMA criteria to be checked and/or amended: 4, 7 and 8
Response:
Now revised (Page 6-11).

VERSION 2 – REVIEW

REVIEWER	Helen Morgan Cardiff University, SURE, University Library Service
REVIEW RETURNED	28-Mar-2021

GENERAL COMMENTS	Thank you to the authors for including, as per the PRISMA checklist, one full electronic search strategy. However the presented search strategy is not comprehensive and therefore there is a risk of publication bias in that not all literature has been retrieved. Mostly only indexed terms have been used, the majority of which have not be translated into free text terms. Not all possible interventions are represented by terms within the strategy, such as those centered around communication. The authors need to refer to PRISMA which recommends peer review of search strategies, https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S0895435616000585. Before this manuscript is re-submitted the search strategies need to be redesigned and re-run to ensure that there is more certainty that all relevant literature has been identified. In considering revision, the following should also be noted: The conclusions are over stated, only 3 cRTCs were identified and were not significant for the outcomes reported, although not all p values provided in manuscript. The other quasi-studies varied in significance of outcomes. The conclusions need to be re-written to be more reflective of the results and not lump all the results together. Abstract, line 53: incorrectly stated that all cRCT are of low risk of bias. Line 139: 'indicator' not plural Line 146/147: 'performed at'? Line 198: Embase (Ovid) database Line 212: delete the 'to Endnote' Line 218: 'were read' Line 269: 'were retrieved from the database ...' Line 278: 'Southern' Line 281: 'studies conducted in either...' delete 'as well as' Line 289: 'had a low risk of bias in the domains for…' Line 297: 'In the eligible studies, n=13, …' Line 316 & 321/322: p value for this result? Line 330: year Line 332: add p value and throughout and table 2 Line 332: 2 references provided, 1 study reported in 2 papers, not clear as listed separately in table 1? Line 333- 338: 3/5 studies statistically significant but only results for one study reported?

	Line 341: year, check throughout for all citations if Harvard style to be used. Line 379: 'test for significance' Discussion: add references Line 408 -411: where is the evidence from your review to suggest this? How do your findings link to those from Warren et al. (2020) Line 413: 'intervention', singular Line 414: 'was more successful' Line 417: 'due to interventions delivered through…' Line 437-443: geographical location of the successful studies? Line 445: what interventions? Add text?

VERSION 2 – AUTHOR RESPONSE

Reviewer #1

Thank you to the authors for including, as per the PRISMA checklist, one full electronic search strategy. However, the presented search strategy is not comprehensive and therefore there is a risk of publication bias in that not all literature has been retrieved.

Response:

The search strategy (including terms) has been comprehensively revised and now reflected in the revised manuscript (Page 9-11, and *Supplementary file 2*)

Mostly only indexed terms have been used, the majority of which have not be translated into free text terms.

Response:

As noted above, point now reflected in the revised manuscript (Page 9-11, and *Supplementary file 2*)

Not all possible interventions are represented by terms within the strategy, such as those centered around communication. The authors need to refer to PRISMA which recommends peer review of search strategies, https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S0895435616000585.

Response:

As noted above, the entire search strategy has been revised with terms including education and counselling, social behavioural change communication, community approaches, health facility approaches, and intervention designs, used. (Page 9-11, and *Supplementary file*).

We note that the revised search strategy with the inclusion of terms centered around communication did not yield any new published articles based on the time interval of the original search. However, we found newly published articles on the topic from June 2020 to May 2021, a period after the manuscript original submission, warranting a substantial revision of relevant sections of the manuscript.

Before this manuscript is re-submitted the search strategies need to be redesigned and re-run to ensure that there is more certainty that all relevant literature has been identified.

Response:

As noted above, we re-confirm that the search strategies were redesigned and re-performed, with advise and multiple reviews from our Medical Librarian, Ms Lily Collision, and now reflected in the revised manuscript [Page 9-11, and *Supplementary file 2*].

The conclusions are over stated, only 3 cRTCs were identified and were not significant for the outcomes reported, although not all p values provided in manuscript. The other quasi-studies varied in significance of outcomes. The conclusions need to be re-written to be more reflective of the results and not lump all the results together.

Response:

Point appreciated and now reflected in the revised manuscript (Page 3 and Page 31).

Abstract, line 53: incorrectly stated that all cRCT are of low risk of bias.

Response:

Revision done (Page 2 line 53-55)

Line 139: 'indicator' not plural

Response:

Revision done (Page 7 line 154)

Line 146/147: 'performed at'?

Response:

Revision done (Page 7 line 161)

Line 198: Embase (Ovid) database

Response:

Revision done (Page 9 line 213)

Line 212: delete the 'to Endnote

Response:

Revision done (Page 11 line 259-260)

Line 218: 'were read'

Response:

Revision done (Page 11 line 265)

Line 269: ‘were retrieved from the database ...’

Response:

Revision done (Page 14 line 318)

Line 278: ‘Southern’

Response:

Now revised (Page 14 line 330).

Line 281: ‘studies conducted in either...’ delete ‘as well as’

Response:

Now revised (Page 14 line 332-333).

Line 289: ‘had a low risk of bias in the domains for…’

Response:

Now revised (Page 14 line 340-341).

Line 297: ‘In the eligible studies, n=13, …’

Response:

Now revised (Page 15 line 351).

Line 316 & 321/322: p value for this result?

Response:

Now revised in the entire manuscript as appropriate

Line 330: year

Response:

Revised throughout the manuscript.

Line 332: add p value and throughout and table 2

Response:

As noted above, revision done.

Line 332: 2 references provided, 1 study reported in 2 papers, not clear as listed separately in table 1?

Response:

As noted above, revision done (Page 17 line 394).

Line 333- 338: 3/5 studies statistically significant but only results for one study reported?

Response:

Now revised (Page 16-17).

Line 341: year, check throughout for all citations if Harvard style to be used.

Response:

Revision done throughout the revised manuscript

Line 379: 'test for significance'

Response:

Now revised (Page 24 line 464).

Discussion: add references

Response:

Now revised (Page 28 Paragraph 1).

Line 408 -411: where is the evidence from your review to suggest this? How do your findings link to those from Warren et al. (2020)

Response:

Now revised (Page 29 Paragraph 1).

Line 413: ‘intervention’, singular

Response:

Now revised (Page 29 line 520).

Line 414: ‘was more successful’

Response:

Now revised (Page 29 line 521).

Line 417: ‘due to interventions delivered through…’

Response:

Now revised (Page 29 line 524-525).

Line 437-443: geographical location of the successful studies?

Response:

Now revised (Page 30 line 541-542).

Line 445: what interventions? Add text?

Response:

Now revised (Page 30 line 553-555).

VERSION 3 – REVIEW

REVIEWER	Helen Morgan Cardiff University, SURE, University Library Service
REVIEW RETURNED	15-Jun-2021

GENERAL COMMENTS	Thank you for addressing my previous comments. Please can you check the following: Date and coverage of searches: Abstract, page 2, line 40 - did searches only go back to 2019 or do you mean to say when the searches were conducted? provide dates of coverage not just when searches conducted. Methods, page 9, line 214-215 - provide dates of coverage not just when searches conducted. Supplementary file 2: line 77 of search strategy indicates that searches only covered periods from 2020 - 2021, is that correct? Or were searches conducted to include evidence publsihed before 2020?

	Numbers of studies per outcome: For each outcome please check the numbers of studies reported is consistent between text and table, particularly when presenting each ouctome and significant findings in results and discussion.

VERSION 3 – AUTHOR RESPONSE

Reviewer #1

Thank you for addressing my previous comments. Please can you check the following:

Response:

We thank the reviewer for the feedback, and the reviewer's specific comments are addressed below.

Date and coverage of searches:

Abstract, page 2, line 40 - did searches only go back to 2019 or do you mean to say when the searches were conducted? provide dates of coverage not just when searches conducted.

Response:

Revision done (Page 2 line 40)

Methods, page 9, line 214-215 - provide dates of coverage not just when searches conducted

Response:

Revision done (Page 9 line 215-217)

Supplementary file 2: line 77 of search strategy indicates that searches only covered periods from

2020 - 2021, is that correct? Or were searches conducted to include evidence publsihed before

2020?

Response:

We are sorry that the caption of *Supplementary file 2* was not clear. We would like to note that that all electronic searchers of the current study were conducted for publications from the year 2000 to March 2021. This information is now noted in the revised manuscript *(Page 2 and 9, and supplementary file 2 and 3).*

Numbers of studies per outcome:

For each outcome, please check the numbers of studies reported is consistent between text and

table, particularly when presenting each outcome and significant findings in results and discussion

Response:

The reviewer has eyes for details – thank you for the observation! Now revision done in the entire revised manuscript.